A QUESTION OF TRUST

Class 10 Master Revision | Footprints Without Feet

By Victor Canning



The Central Mystery: It is said that you must set a thief to catch a thief. But it is also said that there is honour among thieves. Which saying does this story illustrate?

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Who is Horace Danby?





THE PUBLIC FACADE

- 50 years old, unmarried, good, and respectable.
- Runs a successful lock-making business with two helpers.

PHYSICAL VULNERABILITY:
Generally healthy, except for severe attacks of hay fever in the summer.

THE HIDDEN REALITY

- Not completely honest.
- Served his first and only sentence in a prison library 15 years ago.

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The Obsession: Rare & Expensive Books



1

FREQUENCY:
Robs exactly one safe every year.



2

YIELD:
Steals enough to last for twelve months.



3

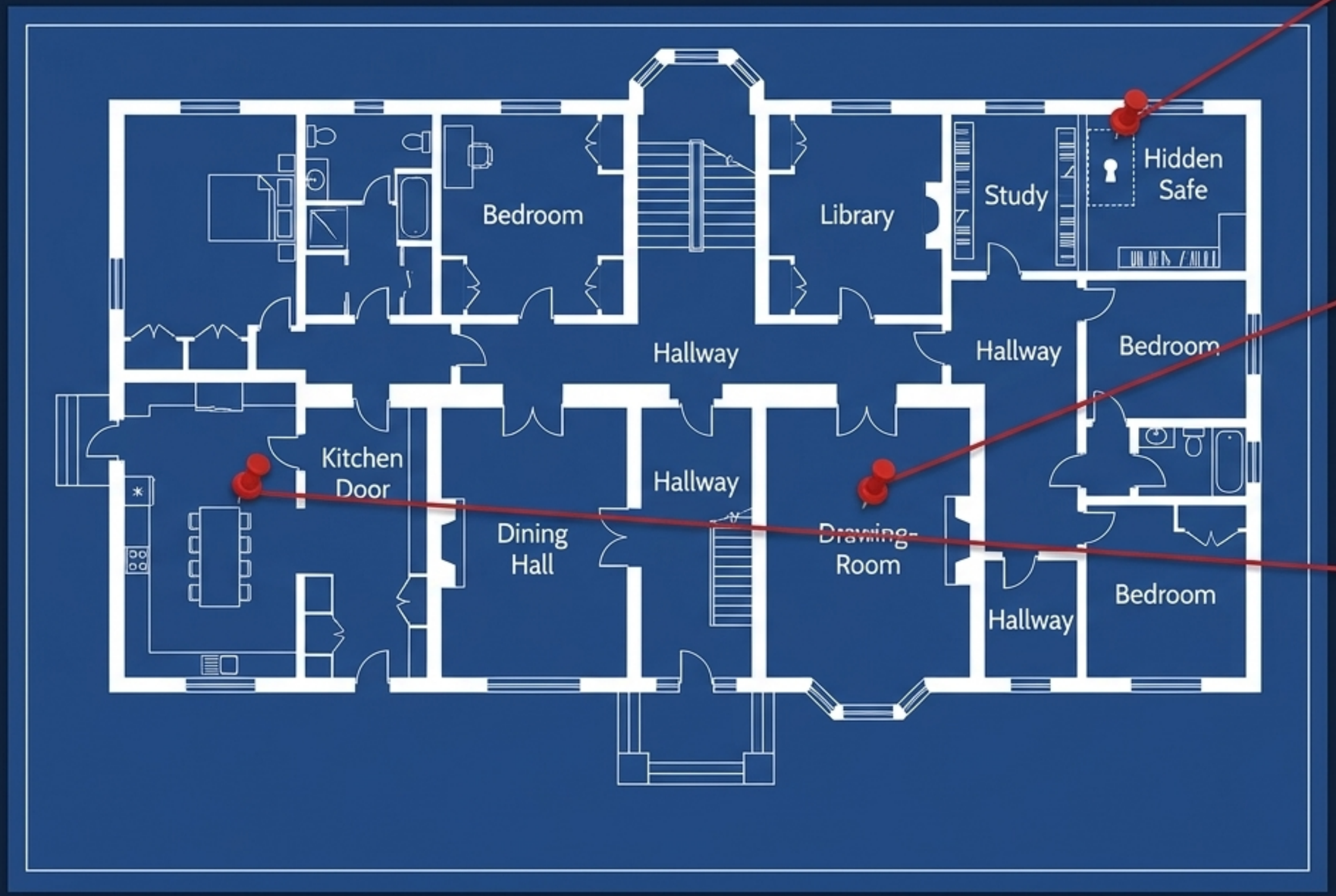
METHOD:
Secretly buys the books he loves through an agent.

THE IMMEDIATE GOAL

Three very interesting books are coming up for sale in the autumn. He needs the money to buy them.

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The Shotover Grange Plan



THE PRIZE

Fifteen thousand pounds' worth of jewels in the Grange safe.

Expected to fetch at least five thousand when sold.

THE RECONNAISSANCE

Two weeks of meticulously studying rooms, electric wiring, paths, and gardens.

THE PERFECT OPPORTUNITY

The family is in London. The two servants who remained at the Grange have gone to the movies for the afternoon.

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Entering the Grange



THE KEY: Taken from a hook outside the kitchen door. Horace strictly wears gloves to leave no fingerprints.



THE DOG (SHERRY): Kept quiet by a professional trick—calling the dog by by its right name and showing love.



THE OBSTACLE: The safe is hidden behind a poor painting. A bowl of flowers triggers his hay fever, hindering his work.

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The Unexpected Lady



THE VOICE

Quiet, kindly, but firm. “What is it? A cold or hay fever?”

THE ASSUMPTION

She straightens the ornaments on the fireplace and acts exactly like the lady of the house returning unexpectedly from London.

THE APPEARANCE

Young, quite pretty, dressed in red. She acts entirely at home, confidently petting the dog: “Down, Sherry.”

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A Psychological Duel



THE LADY'S COUNTER

"Why should I? You were going to rob me. If I let you go, you'll only rob someone else. Society must be protected from men like you."

HORACE'S THREAT

"I would, of course, cut the telephone wires first and then... I would make sure that you could do nothing for some time."

HORACE'S WEAKNESS

He drops the threat and begs. He claims he only steals from those with a lot of money and is absolutely desperate to avoid prison.

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Setting the Bait

THE DEAL
She promises to let him go, BUT only if he does something for her.

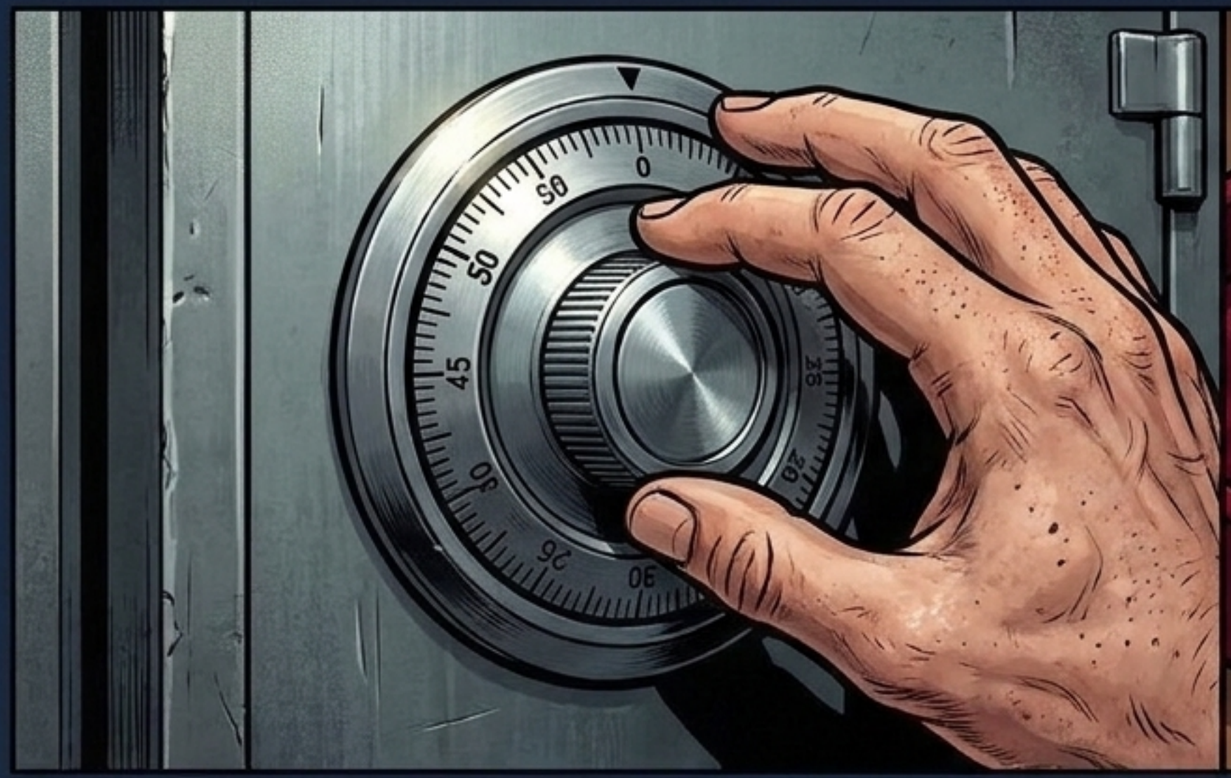
THE FAKE STORY
She claims she promised her husband to take her jewels to the bank, but left them in the safe. She says she needs to wear them to a party tonight.

THE TRAP
She claims she has forgotten the numbers to open the safe, trapping Horace in his own expertise and need to please her.



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The Fatal Mistake





EAGER TO PLEASE
Desperate to secure his freedom, Horace removes his gloves to offer her his cigarette lighter.

THE ACT
Blinded by relief, he breaks open the safe within an hour, completely forgetting to put his gloves back on.

THE ESCAPE
He hands her the jewels and leaves the house happily, fully believing he has avoided prison.

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The Truth Revealed



THE REAL OWNER
The actual wife of the owner of the house is a gray-haired, sharp-tongued woman of sixty.

THE REALIZATION
The young woman in red was NOT the owner. She was simply another thief who brilliantly outsmarted him.

For two days, Horace kept his promise.

On the third day, he is arrested for the jewel robbery at Shotover Grange.

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The Arrest & The Evidence



THE FINGERPRINTS

Because he removed his gloves to help the “lady,” his prints were found all over the room.

THE DEFENSE

Horace desperately tells the police that the owner’s wife asked him to open the safe.

THE VERDICT

The real wife angrily calls his story “nonsense.” Because of his record and the physical evidence, no one believes him.

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The Final Irony



THE CONSEQUENCE
Horace is now the assistant librarian in the prison.

THE MEMORY
He often thinks of the charming, clever young lady in his own profession who tricked him.

THE THEME
He gets very angry whenever anyone talks about "honour among thieves." The story proves that in the criminal world, ultimate vulnerability lies in trusting another thief.

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Master Timeline: The Shotover Case



1. THE TARGET

Horace studies Shotover Grange to steal jewels to fund his passion for rare books.



2. THE ENTRY

Sneaks in perfectly, manages the dog, but an attack of hay fever.



3. THE ENCOUNTER

Caught by a confident woman in red claiming to be the owner of the house.



4. THE DEAL

She asks him to open the safe; he removes his gloves in his panic to please her.



5. THE BETRAYAL

Arrested 3 days later. The woman in red was actually a rival thief.

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NCERT Keyword Vault

Hay fever

A disorder affecting the nose and throat, caused by allergy to pollen or dust.

Respectable

Regarded by society to be good, proper, or correct.

Hindering

Making it difficult for someone to do something.

Persuaded

Convinced someone to do or believe something through reasoning or begging.

Sharp-tongued

Using critical, harsh, or angry language.

Honour among thieves

The belief that criminals have a moral code and do not commit crimes against each other.

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Board Exam Booster: Character Contrast

Dimension	Horace Danby	The Lady in Red
Facade	Respectable citizen & careful planner.	Wealthy owner & authoritative figure.
Motive	Steals for passion (rare books).	Steals for pure wealth (jewels).
Demeanor	Easily panicked, naive, susceptible to fear.	Calm under pressure, highly manipulative, subtle.

Where did Horace falter?

He was a meticulous planner, but blind trust and the intense fear of prison made him forget golden rule: always wear gloves.

How did she deceive him?

Subtlety. Petted the dog by name, arranged ornaments, spoke with authority, and played on his fear of prison.

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